

THE DELHI SULTANATE

Five Dynasties • 1206 – 1526 AD

Slave (Mamluk) → Khilji → Tughlaq → Sayyid → Lodi | ends with the First Battle of Panipat, 1526

- Headings & Definitions
- Explanations
- Highlighter = Key Facts
- 🎯 Exam Tip
- ✗ Common Mistake
- 🧠 Memory Trick

StudyPlanner



View:



Page-by-Page



Continuous Scroll



Print

SETTING THE STAGE — THE DELHI SULTANATE

Five dynasties ruled the Delhi Sultanate, one after another, from 1206 AD to 1526 AD: Slave (Mamluk), then Khilji, then Tughlaq, then Sayyid, then Lodi.

Dynasty	Time Period
Slave / Mamluk	1206 – 1290 AD
Khilji	1290 – 1320 AD
Tughlaq	1320 – 1414 AD
Sayyid	1414 – 1451 AD
Lodi	1451 – 1526 AD

Slave 1206 → Khilji 1290 → Tughlaq 1320 → Sayyid 1414 → Lodi 1451–1526



Memory Trick

Remember the order using the first letters: **S-K-T-S-L** — Slave, Khilji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi. Say it out loud a few times like a chant before the exam!

Why "Slave Dynasty"?

It is called the **Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty** because its important rulers were slaves of one another. Most belonged to the **Ilbari tribe** — for example, Qutbuddin Aibak himself belonged to this tribe.

1 Qutbuddin Aibak (1206 – 1210 AD)



- He was a **slave of Muhammad Ghori**
- Ruled for four years, from 1206 to 1210 AD
- Capital: **Lahore**
- Built **Adhai Din Ka Jhonpra** (in Ajmer) and the **Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque**
- Quwwat-ul-Islam was built using the **corbel arch** technique
- Started construction of the **Qutub Minar**, in memory of his guru, the Sufi saint **Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki**
- Title: **Lakh Baksh** (Giver of Lakhs) — because he donated lakhs in charity
- Died while playing **polo** (a horseback game)



Fig 1: The Qutub Minar – Who Built What?

Top (5th) storey:
Firoz Shah Tughlag
(after lightning damage)

Storeys 1–4:
started by Aibak,
completed by Iltutmish

5 storeys total

✗ Common Mistake

Don't say "Qutbuddin Aibak built the Qutub Minar" — he only **started** its construction. It was **completed by Iltutmish** (5 storeys total), and the **top storey was rebuilt by**

Firoz Shah Tughlaq after it was damaged by lightning.

📖 *Adhai Din Ka Jhonpra – quick note (tap to expand) ▼*



🧠 Memory Trick

"Lakh Baksh" = Lakhs + Baksh (to give) → the sultan who gave away lakhs in charity. Link the title directly to the meaning, don't just memorise the word!

Page 1 of 6

← Previous

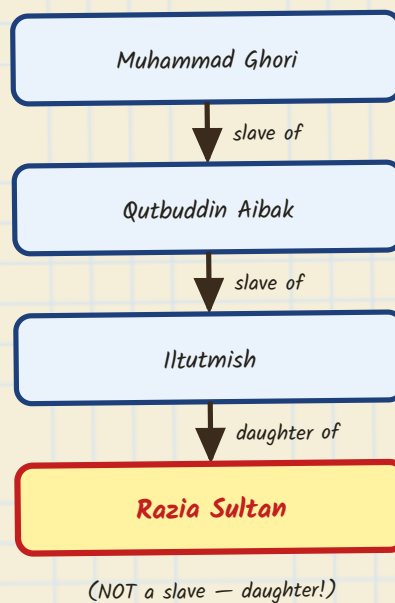
Next →



ILTUTMISH + RAZIA SULTAN 2 *Iltutmish (1210 – 1236 AD)*

Iltutmish was a slave of Qutbuddin Aibak, just as Aibak had been a slave of Muhammad Ghori.

🔗 Fig 2: The Slave Succession Chain



- Shifted the capital from **Lahore to Delhi** — because Qutbuddin Aibak's son was based in Lahore

- Introduced coins: the silver **Tanka** and the copper **Jital**
- Introduced the **Chahalgani system** — a group of 40 Turkish loyal slaves given command of the entire administration
- Introduced the **Iqta system**
- His vizier (Prime Minister) was **Nizam-ul-Mulk**



Understand the Iqta system like this...

A military commander was given a piece of land (an **Iqta**). In return, he had to maintain troops and support the Sultan in battles. What did he get? The right to collect **revenue** from that land. The holder was called a **Muqti / Wali**.



Memory Trick

Chahalgani = "Chahal" sounds like 40 in Persian → **Group of 40 Turkish slaves** controlling the whole administration for Iltutmish.

During his reign, **Genghis Khan** invaded the region around India while chasing a man — Iltutmish refused to give that man shelter, and so Genghis Khan did not attack India directly.

3 **Razia Sultan (1236 – 1240 AD)**

- She was the **daughter of Iltutmish** — not a slave
- She was the **first female Islamic ruler** in medieval history, and the only woman ruler of the Delhi Sultanate
- Ruled for only four years



In his book *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri*, the chronicler **Minhaj-i-Siraj** described **Razia Sultan** as more capable than even Iltutmish's own sons.



Razia Sultan's downfall — full story (tap to expand) ▼



Common Mistake

Don't call Razia Sultan a "slave ruler" — **Aibak** and **Iltutmish** were slaves, but Razia was Iltutmish's **daughter**, not a slave.

Exam Tip

Ilutmish's 3 pillars: **Tanka (silver) + Jital (copper) + Chahalgani (40 slaves) + Iqta system** — and he shifted the capital from Lahore to Delhi. Learn these together as one block.

Page 2 of 6

← Previous

Next →

FROM BALBAN TO THE RISE OF THE KHILTIS

Between 1240 and 1266 AD, weak puppet rulers were installed by the Chahalgani whenever it suited them — for example **Muizuddin Bahram Shah**, a son of Ilutmish.

4 Balban (1266 – 1287 AD)

- He himself was a **slave of Ilutmish** and part of the Chahalgani
- Before becoming Sultan, he was the **Naib** (chief minister) under the earlier ruler, **Nasiruddin Mahmud**
- Broke the power of the Chahalgani to secure his own authority
- Declared himself **Zill-i-Ilahi** — "Shadow of God"
- Introduced the customs of **Sijda and Paibos** — subjects had to prostrate and kiss the monarch's feet
- Claimed descent from the royal family of **Afrasiyab**
- Followed the "**Blood and Iron**" policy — e.g. crushing the rebellion of **Tughril Beg**, the Governor of Bengal
- Title: **Ulugh Khan**
- Started the Persian festival **Navroz**

Exam Tip

Balban's four "power" ideas go together: **broke the Chahalgani → Zill-i-Ilahi → Sijda-Paibos → Blood and Iron policy** — all about strengthening the throne.

Balban's grandson **Kaigubad** became the last ruler of the Slave Dynasty (1287–1290 AD). He was killed by **Jalaluddin Khilji**, who then founded the Khilji Dynasty.

5 Khilji Dynasty Begins (1290 – 1320 AD)

- **Jalaluddin Khilji** (1290–1296 AD) was the first ruler — nothing else major is studied about him
- He was killed by his own nephew (who was also married to his daughter) — **Alauddin Khilji**

6 Alauddin Khilji (1296 – 1316 AD)

- Real name: **Ali Gurshasp**
- First expedition: **Gujarat, 1298 AD** — he looted it, and here he found the slave **Malik Kafur**, bought for **1000 dinars** (hence also called "Hazar Dinari")
- Expedition to **Ranthambore**, and to **Mewar (1303 AD)** — king of Mewar was **Raja Ratan Singh**, capital Chittor
- Also expeditions to **Malwa** and **Jalore**

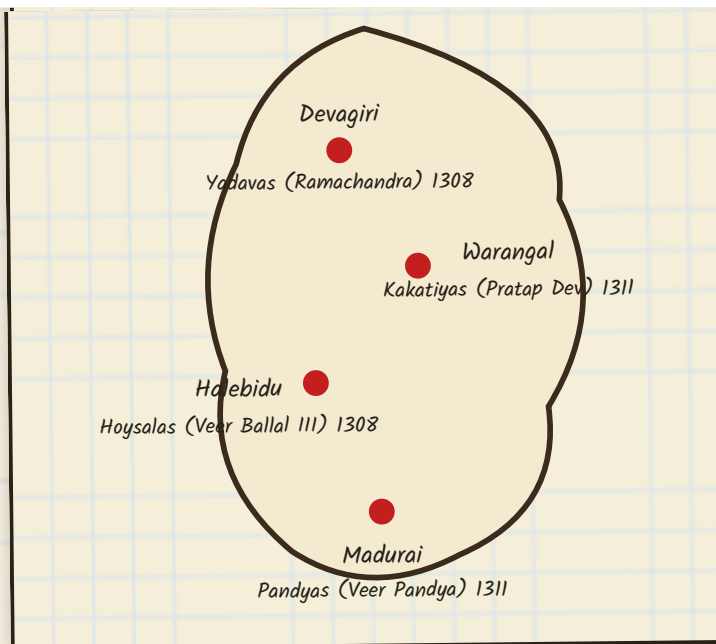
🔥 **Jauhar** — where Rajput women immolated themselves rather than be taken into the Harem (Islamic royal household). The first Jauhar happened at Mewar/Chittor.

📖 **Padmavat** — backstory (tap to expand) ▼

Malik Kafur's Deccan Campaigns

Malik Kafur led all of Alauddin's expeditions into **South India**, plundering (not yet conquering/ruling) the Deccan kingdoms one by one.

📍 Fig 3: Malik Kafur's Deccan Campaigns



Kingdom	Ruler	Year
Yadavas of Devagiri	Raja Ramachandra	1308 AD
Hoyasalas of Halebidu / Dwarasamudram	Veer Ballal III	1308 AD
Kakatiyas of Warangal	Pratap Dev	1300 / 1311 AD
Pandyas of Madurai	Veer Pandya	1311 AD

✗ Common Mistake

Malik Kafur only **plundered** the Deccan kingdoms for Alauddin Khilji — he did not establish direct Delhi Sultanate rule there. Real conquest of the Deccan came only in the **Mughal era**.

Page 3 of 6

← Previous

Next →



ALAUDDIN KHILJI — REFORMS, TITLES + LEGACY

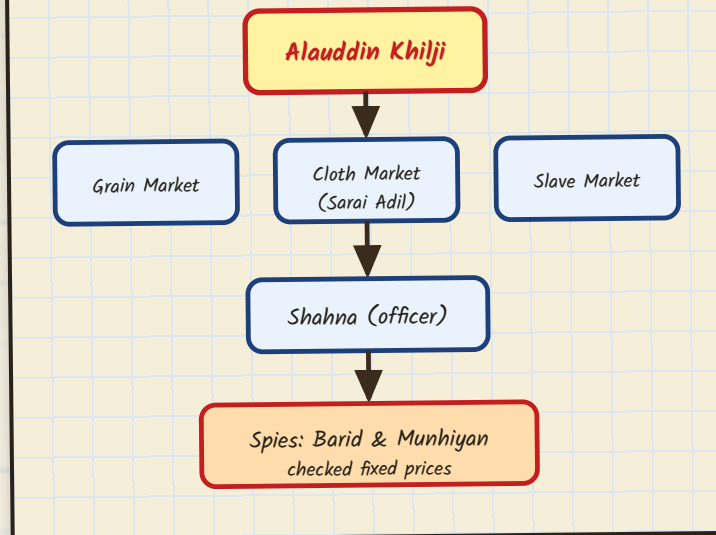
Market Reforms

Alauddin paid his soldiers low salaries but kept them happy by strictly controlling market prices.

- Three markets were set up: **Grain market**, **Cloth market** (called **Sarai Adil**), and the **Slave market**
- Each market was controlled by an officer called a **Shahna**
- Spies called **Barid** and **Munhiyan** checked whether goods were being sold at fixed prices



Fig 4: Alauddin's Market Control System



✗ Common Mistake

Don't mix up the roles: the **Shahna** was the officer who ran/regulated the market itself, while **Barid & Munhiyan** were spies who secretly checked whether the fixed prices were actually being followed.

Taxes

- **Kharaj** — land tax paid by farmers
- **Ghari** — house tax
- **Charai** — pastoral (grazing) tax



🧠 Memory Trick

Ghari-Charai-Kharaj = **House-Pasture-Land**. Three taxes, three types of property!



Daag & Chehra System

Daag = branding of horses (a stamp, to prevent double counting). **Chehra** = the *Huliya* system — a descriptive roll of each soldier's appearance.

Titles & Court

- Title **Sikandar-i-Sani** ("Second Alexander") given by his court poet **Amir Khusrau**
- Amir Khusrau himself was titled **Tuti-i-Hind** ("Parrot of India")
- Amir Khusrau wrote **Nuh Sipihr** and **Tughlaq Nama**, and is credited with inventing the **sitar**
- Established the department **Diwan-e-Mustakhraj** — for clearing pending/arrear payments

Buildings

- **Alai Fort** and **Alai Darwaza** (entrance gateway to the Qutub Minar complex)
- **Hauz Khas**
- Founded the city of **Siri** with **Siri Fort** — the second city of Delhi



Exam Tip

Alauddin Khilji also abolished the Iqta system that Iltutmish had introduced — remember this "abolish" fact carefully, since it gets reversed later by Firoz Shah Tughlaq!



The messy succession after Alauddin (tap to expand) ▼

Page 4 of 6

← Previous

Next →



THE TUGHLAQ DYNASTY (1320 - 1414 AD)

7

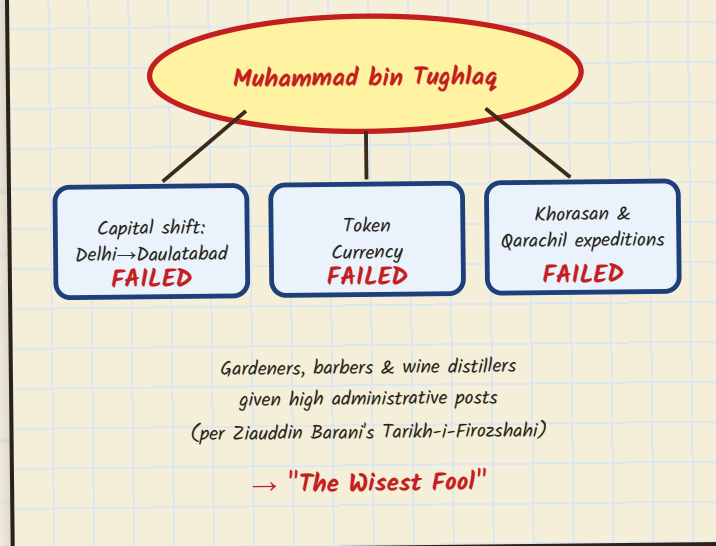
Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq (1320 - 1325 AD)

Built the city of **Tughlaqabad** and the **Tughlaqabad Fort**.

8 Muhammad bin Tughlaq – the "Wisest Fool"

Known as **Prince Jauna** or **Ulugh Khan** before becoming Sultan. Called the "**Wisest Fool**" because his ideas were clever in theory but failed badly in execution.

Fig 5: Three Bold Ideas – All Failed!



- Shifted the capital from Delhi to **Daulatabad** (Devagiri, earlier ruled by the Yadavas) — to help conquer South India, then reversed the decision when it failed
- Introduced a **token currency**, which also failed
- His **Khorasan and Qarachil** expeditions (towards Iran/Himalayan region) failed; disbanding the army raised for it led to looting
- Per chronicler **Ziauddin Barani's Tarikh-i-Firozshahi**, he appointed a gardener (**Ladha** and **Peera**), a barber (**Firoz Hajjam**), and a wine distiller (**Aziz Khumar**) to high administrative posts
- Established the department **Diwan-e-Kohi** — the Department of Agriculture



Memory Trick

Gardner's names: **Ladha & Peera** — an easy exam-favourite pair to remember by sound.

During his time, the traveller **Ibn Battuta**, from Morocco, visited India and later wrote the travelogue **Rihla**.

9 Firoz Shah Tughlaq (1351 – 1388 AD)

He worked to clean up the mess left behind by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.



- Developed many **canals** — a proper irrigation system for agriculture
- Separated the **Jaziya** as its own distinct tax
- Made the **Iqta system hereditary** (remember: Alauddin Khilji had earlier abolished it)
- Founded **Jaunpur** (named after Muhammad bin Tughlaq, i.e. "Jauna," his cousin) and **Firozabad** (named after himself)
- Established two departments: **Diwan-e-Bandagan** (Department of Slaves) and **Diwan-e-Khairat** (Department of Donations)
- Built the hospital **Darul Shifa**
- Rebuilt the top storey of the **Qutub Minar** after lightning damage



Exam Tip

Iqta system timeline: Introduced by Iltutmish → Abolished by Alauddin Khilji → Made hereditary by Firoz Shah Tughlaq. This exact sequence is a favourite exam question!

Later, during the reign of **Mahmud Shah Tughlaq**, **Timur** launched repeated invasions that completely destroyed the Tughlaq Dynasty. Timur's own military commander, **Khizr Khan**, then laid the foundation of the **Sayyid Dynasty**.



Memory Trick

"Wisest Fool" chain: **Daulatabad shift → Token currency → Khorasan/Qarachil expeditions** — three bold, clever-sounding plans, three total failures.



SAYYID + LODI DYNASTIES — END OF THE SULTANATE

10 Sayyid Dynasty (1414 – 1451 AD)

- Founder: **Khizr Khan**
- Members were known as **Kulah-daran**, because they wore a distinctive cone-shaped cap
- Chronicler **Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi** wrote **Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi**, describing the Sayyids as descendants of the Prophet Muhammad

✗ Common Mistake

Every court chronicler tended to flatter the ruling dynasty of their time — remember that **Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi's claim** about the Sayyids' descent comes from a court chronicle, not an independent historical verification.

11 Lodi Dynasty (1451 – 1526 AD) — The Last Dynasty

- Founder: **Bahlol Lodi** (1451–1489 AD), of **Afghan origin**
- **Sikandar Lodi** (1489–1517 AD):
 - Composed poems under the pen name **Gulrukhi**
 - Built the city of **Agra** (1504 AD) and made it his capital in 1506 AD
 - Introduced a unit of measurement, **Gaj-i-Sikandari** (equal to 32 digits)
- The Lodi Dynasty is known for introducing double-dome architecture in India
- **Ibrahim Lodi** (1517–1526 AD) — the last ruler of the entire Delhi Sultanate



🧠 Memory Trick

Sikandar Lodi = Agra (city) + Gulrukhi (pen name) + Gaj-i-Sikandari (measurement)
— three "his-own-name" contributions!

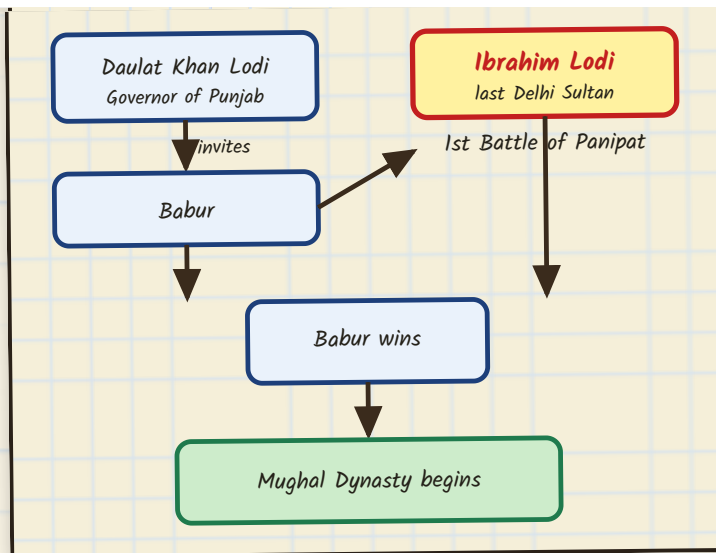


The First Battle of Panipat (1526 AD)

Fought between **Ibrahim Lodi** and **Babur** — **Babur won**, and Ibrahim Lodi was defeated.



Fig 6: The First Battle of Panipat, 1526

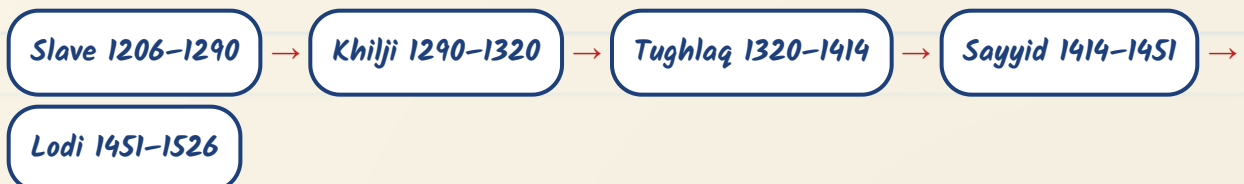


🔑 Just as King Jaichand once invited Muhammad Ghori, Daulat Khan Lodi invited Babur to defeat Ibrahim Lodi – hoping to gain the throne himself. But just as Ghori had done with Jaichand, Babur did the same to Daulat Khan Lodi – and took the throne for himself instead.

🎯 Exam Tip

1526 = double milestone: it marks the end of the Delhi Sultanate (last ruler: Ibrahim Lodi) AND the start of the Mughal Dynasty (Babur) – in the very same battle!

★ Exam-Ready Summary – Delhi Sultanate



- Started: Qutbuddin Aibak, 1206 AD
- Most powerful ruler: Alauddin Khilji (1296–1316 AD)
- "Wisest Fool": Muhammad bin Tughlaq
- Ended: Ibrahim Lodi, defeated at the First Battle of Panipat, 1526 AD
- Result: End of the Delhi Sultanate → start of the Mughal Dynasty (Babur)

